

WHAT DO I NEED AND HOW DO I GET IT?

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Maintain a program of recovery free of addiction and negative influences from peers.
2. Understand that continuing to associate with the current peer group increases the risk of relapse.
3. Learn the skills necessary to develop a new peer group that is addiction-free and supportive of working a program of recovery.
4. Address fears related to giving up the former peer group.
5. Find healthier ways to meet needs that old peer relationships fulfilled.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PEER GROUP NEGATIVITY

- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- Being Genuinely Unselfish
- Building My Support Network
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Relapse Prevention Planning
- Setting and Maintaining Boundaries
- Using My Support Network
- What Do Others See Changing?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Dependent Traits
- Legal Problems
- Living Environment Deficiencies

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “What Do I Need and How Do I Get It?” activity is suited for the client whose recovery efforts are undermined by peer interactions, whether the client realizes this or not. It guides the client to assess this for him/herself and to draw appropriate conclusions. It is important to keep in mind that the client may not feel ready to cut ties with his/her old peer group and may not believe that peer associations affect his/her recovery. Multiple efforts may be needed to deal with the minimization or denial

that accompanies this belief. Further, there is likely to be fear and grief related to ending peer relationships, even if the client understands that their influence is negative. It may be useful to role-play ways to end unhealthy relationships, as well as to initiate healthy new ones. It may also be useful to help the client educate his/her family and supportive friends about addiction and the recovery process.

WHAT DO I NEED AND HOW DO I GET IT?

Some of the hardest challenges people face in early recovery are relationships with family members, significant others, and friends who continue to engage in addictive behavior or illegal activities, don't understand or support recovery, mock or ignore treatment and recovery, and encourage addictive behaviors. As you get healthier physically, emotionally, and spiritually, you may find you have less and less in common with some of the people who were closest to you before you got into recovery. Each of us has the right and the responsibility to choose with whom we will associate. We deserve to have people in our lives who support our abstinence and recovery and respect our decision to live positively and free of addiction. We need to eliminate risks that lead back toward addictive lifestyle and behaviors, and this may include people with whom we've shared important parts of our lives. To maintain recovery, we need to increase our contact with positive people who support nonaddictive lifestyles. This exercise will help you assess your current peer group for risks, identify the benefits of being around people who support your recovery, and begin identifying what you are willing to do for yourself to create a more positive support system.

1. Please list some situations when peers encouraged you to engage in addictive behavior or illegal activity.

2. We are always responsible for our own choices, but the people we hang out with can be a powerful influence. Does your current peer group support addictive behavior (e.g., do they encourage use, use around you, act unsupportive of your recovery), and if so, how?

3. What are some things you've said, or heard people say, to deny that peers can influence their thinking or behavior, and do you believe those statements are true?

4. Does continued involvement with your peer group increase your risk of relapse? If so, how do your peers undermine your success in treatment? List up to 10 ways.

5. What worries do you have about breaking off your connections with current peers and making new contacts?

6. What are the main advantages and disadvantages to changing your peer group from one that increases your risk of relapse to one that encourages a nonaddictive lifestyle?

Advantages

Disadvantages

7. What needs does your peer group fulfill for you (e.g., fun, excitement, second family, sense of belonging)?

8. Imagine explaining to your peer group your need to end your relationship for your own well-being. What would you want them to know and what would you say?

9. If a friend told you that he or she needed to stop spending time with you for his/her own good, would you accept that and respect your friend's decision? _____ If you said yes, do you deserve that same acceptance and respect from others? _____
10. To increase the likelihood of maintaining abstinence and recovery, each of us needs to develop a new peer group that is free of addictive behaviors and supports our working a program of recovery.
- a. What can you do to increase your opportunities for fellowship with positive peers?
- _____
- _____
- b. What are the ways you will increase social contact with positive peers?
- _____
- _____
- c. What are the benefits to you if you do these things?
- _____
- _____
11. What skills do you believe you need in order to develop new friends? What do you foresee as barriers?
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
12. Determine how each family member can help you in your recovery and write the answers in the following space.
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
13. Write at least a five-step plan for how you will start the process of identifying and making new friends.
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk over your thoughts and feelings about this topic with your therapist or with your group.